

received, though, could perform automatic duplex printing.

In terms of box contents, the Canon LBP 2900 was the only printer to ship without a data cable. For their '1600' printer, WeP decided to go retro and shipped a Parallel Port cable. Thankfully, the rest shipped with USB cables. USB 2.0 was the overall choice, but if you need them, all the printers also had Parallel ports.

The Canon LBP 2900 and 3200 came without a troubleshooting guide. The concept of providing manuals in PDF form is catching on fast, as it saves the manufacturer a bundle in printing costs.

However, we should here mention that connecting printers has become easier and a troubleshooting guide isn't really required anyway! Lexmark, however, bundled every manual you could possibly think of!

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One major thing we found missing was support for different OSes. As a business, the last thing you want is to have to bear the cost of deploying separate printers for each group of OSes that run on your network.

Here, the Samsung and Lexmark printers outshone every other printer with support for Windows, Linux and even MACs. The rest only support Windows and/or Linux. Keep this in mind if your company uses MACs.

We then came to one of the most important features in an office printer: Network support. You will need Ethernet support if you plan to deploy the printer on an office LAN. Unfortunately, none of the printers were network-ready. The Lexmark, both Canons and the Samsung ML 1710P, at least had the option of upgrading to one later. So, if you feel your business might grow and need a

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network-capable printer in the future, choose one of these for your office.

Performance

With inspections and observations out of the way, it was time to get on with the tests.

We started by noting down their warm-up times. This is the time a printer takes to get 'ready' to print its first page. Despite claims by Canon about zero warm-up time, we found that their LBP 2900 and 3200 printers took 6.1 and 5.2 seconds respectively.

Though the Canon LBP 3200 had the shortest warm-up time, the Xerox 3116 was a close second at just 5.4 seconds. Samsung's ML 1710P and WeP's 1600 came in last with times of 10 and 9.8 seconds respectively.

Keep in mind, however, that although some printers may take longer to warm-up it's the printing speed and quality that eventually matter more. For a SoHo environment, a 10-second wait for the first print may not matter so much!

In terms of print speeds, the fastest were the Canons—the LBP 3200 being the fastest. It managed to print our text test pages in a mere 9.06 and 9.16 seconds at 'Normal' and 'Best' qualities respectively.

The Canon LBP 2900 took 11.33 seconds at Normal quality, and 11.4 seconds in Best quality mode. A pattern was emerging: hardly any time difference between printing in Normal or Best modes was being thrown up. The sole exception to the rule turned out to be the WeP 1600. At 14.2 and 24.6 seconds respectively, it finished last.

